

ONE

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Do I really have it in me? I asked myself almost inaudibly. A strange silence fell over me as I stared at my reflection in the glass window of the AC coach. My train to Mysore had just arrived, and I was supposed to board soon.

Am I worthy of becoming an officer in the Indian armed forces? I asked myself, looking at my reflection, unmoving. Even the PA announcement by the railway station staff failed to distract me. Beads of sweat collected on my face and at the back of my neck. Whether it was my body's mechanism of cooling itself down on a hot July afternoon, or just me perspiring out of nervousness, I could not tell. We had been waiting for the train at the platform in the scorching heat for an hour, and it may have well been the weather of Chennai. But then again, the opportunity that I had been eagerly waiting for was just hours away, so it could very well have been nervousness, after all.

'The train will leave in five minutes.' It was my father's voice that pulled me back to reality. All of a sudden, discreet chatter, PA announcements, the incessant hollering of hawkers, the train's honking, the sound of a radio somewhere playing the title track from *Hum Aapke Hain Kaun* filled the air. In this country, railway stations have always been crowded and busy. I